

NOTES

The Fourth Regular Meeting of the Medford School Committee

Monday, February 28, 2022

Executive Session: 6:00PM

Regular Meeting: 6:30 PM

Held at the Howard Alden Memorial Chambers, Medford City Hall.

Also presented on Zoom:

<https://mps02155-org.zoom.us/j/97089428322>

Meeting ID: 970 8942 8322

6:02 PM Roll Call for Attendance of Members and the Student Representatives

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Mayor

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7 present/0 Absent

Student Representative - not here

Salute the Flag

Negotiations and Legal Matters - Executive Session: 6:00PM (not in Chambers)

Upon a Motion to enter into executive session pursuant to M. G.L. c. 30A §21(a) .

Executive session of the Medford School Committee pursuant to G.L. c. 30A §21(a) to conduct a strategy session on the basis that an open meeting may have a detrimental effect on the bargaining or litigating positions of the Medford School Committee. Specifically, the Medford School Committee will be discussing a class action grievance pending before the American Arbitration Association.

7 affirmative/0 negative: Motion passed to enter Executive Session

Return from Executive Session

Consent Agenda

- Approval of Bills/Payrolls
- Regular School Committee Meeting Minutes, 2.7.2022

Motion to approve: Mea Mustone

7/0 Consent agenda approved

Report of the Superintendent

1. [Superintendent's Updates and Comments](#) - Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Superintendent
Also, a gathering to support the people of Ukraine, this Friday night at MHS at 7:00PM. It will be coordinated by the students of CCSR.
2. [COVID Update](#) - Assistant Superintendent of Finance & Operations David Murphy and Avery Hines Director of Health Services will report on operational updates and pending COVID shifts in the Medford Public Schools. Director of the Medford Board of Health MaryAnn O'Connor will report on the latest COVID data in Medford.

Dave Murphy: We know that there are strong opinions on both sides regarding masking. An additional two weeks of masks after the vacation week provides safety for our most vulnerable. We know that our students will handle this with the same grace they have exhibited all year. The way we meet these challenges needs to evolve. We are transitioning from building wide surveillance testing to at home diagnostic testing.

Member Hays: What will be in place after pooled testing ends this week?

Dave Murphy: The first layer is the at home testing distribution. Our health services will continue to be available to do testing

Avery Hines: To do testing in the nurse's office, we need the initial consent form. Parents are able to give consent to nurses over the phone. After the rapid test, the PCR test gets sent out and takes 24 hours to get results.

Sharon Hays: Now we are not doing contact tracing, how do families with high risk persons find out about cases?

Dave Murphy: Our transition on March 14 is going to mask optional but students can continue to wear masks ongoing.

Avery Hines: If you have someone at home who is vulnerable, please let the nurse's office know.

Jenny Graham: Are there members of the audience who want to speak on this topic?

Tiffany Bear: I am confused as to what scientific evidence you are citing? They have been wearing masks that don't even protect them for months. I have studies on masks not working. Students are missing out. It is time to strengthen their immunity. I have worked the front line the entire pandemic without a mask. You say you are following the CDC but the CDC says you can take them off.

Supt. Edoard-Vincent: Our data is that we saw an increase after vacations of positive tests. In collaboration with the Board of Health, we determined the date of Monday, March 14. We have all been masking for two years. We can handle the extra nine days.

Tiffany Bear (sp?): What data do you have showing that people who tested positive actually got sick? You can be positive PCR and not have COVID.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: We don't have that specific data you are looking for.

Paul Ruseau: We have other hands up on ZOOM.

Andrea Polcaro, 42 Guild Street: Literally the Board of Health removed the mask mandate from the rest of Medford. My children are not even in school because they were treated so poorly when they brought a doctor's note saying they didn't have to wear a mask. Only nine more days is very condescending. It has been two years for these innocent children. I want to see the data on who is getting sick.

Melanie Tringale: Forest Street, You say you are following CDC guidelines but you really are not. CDC guidelines show that our county is low risk (hospitalization and deaths). The only uptick was in January during Omicron. There is no data showing a current uptick. Schools have never been known to be superspreaders.

Melanie McLaughlin: I would like to note that while this is a topic for many, we have gotten many emails from both sides. We are all parents here and I care about all students and err on the side of caution. Additionally, over 941 thousand people have died of COVID. I believe that the March 14 date was a happy medium. The superintendent, admin and nursing staff have worked so hard. When are we going to stop fighting?

June Falco: It was just stated that over 940 thousand people have died of COVID 19. Even Fauci has said that many people have died with COVID 19 and not from COVID-19. I am still awaiting response from MOC, the Mayor and the Supt. that these masks are approved for emergency use authorization and it is no longer a medical emergency.

Mary Ann O'Connor: I have responded to your email that I am in disagreement regarding your term of medical devices.

June Falco: You did answer me and you don't want to refer to them as medical device. I gave you a link to CDC regarding cloth masks being emergency use authorization.

Mary Ann O'Connor: I continue to disagree and we can take this offline.

Jessica Healy: I know that you are saying after February vacation you are masking for two weeks. Does that mean that you will do this again for April vacation? Also buses?

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: We are hopeful that the rates will continue to decline and we have no plans to institute masks after April vacation.

Dave Murphy: With respect to the buses, the guidance just came out. We spoke with our bus vendor. As for now the bus mandate continues until March 14.

Kim DeGregorio: Thanks to the Supt. for extending this until March 14. These people need to think about the kids who will face life long consequences from this disease.

Allison Leed, 31 Kilgore Ave: Medical scientist. Thanks to the Admin for keeping our kids safe so far. The testing program and the masking have been keeping kids safe. It is hard to listen to these comments about scientific inaccuracy.

Christina McGorty: 24 North Street. I am thankful that the mask mandate didn't end today but I also want to urge the administration to extend the mandate after the 14th. I am hoping that we will get information going forward regarding the at home testing program. It seems like a lot of change at once. Our vaccination rate is not that high with the 5 to 18 year olds. I feel strongly that we continue to offer clinics and wait for the under 5 year olds to become vaccinated. Perhaps we can start with the high schoolers.

Kerry Laidlaw: 194 Fells Avenue: Will the children be discriminated against if they show up without masks? They won't be ridiculed, bullied because they do not wear masks?

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: Your children will not be discriminated against.

Melanie Raelin: 61 Brewster Road: Thanks to the Supt and SC for everything they have been doing. The tracker has been very helpful. I wish that people who were vaccinated in the schools would have been automatically enrolled in the home testing program. Encouraging continued mask wearing. Mask wearing protects the mask wearer as well as the people they face. In Worcester, they gave up on the mandate before break and they have seen more cases.

3. Request for Approval of District Mural - Principal Paul D'Alleva and Medford Family Network Director Marie Cassidy will report on a community-based mural project outside the west corridor of the MHS.

Marie Cassidy: You all have some information about an art installation that will be installed at MHS. Arts Medford has helped us pursue this grant. The installation is to be created by families.

Principal Paul D'Alleva: The mosaic will be put on a platform that will be screwed to the building. It will be able to be removed if something happens with the building. We did something similar at the Andrews.

Motion to approve: Mea Mustone/Seconded by Kathy Kreatz

Roll: Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn:, YES 7/0 Paper passes.

4. Math After School Tutoring/Enrichment Program - Assistant Superintendent of Elementary Education Suzanne Galusi will report on an upcoming skill building math intervention program.

[Link to Slides](#)

Melanie McLaughlin: This sounds great. Could you let me know about the group size? Is it available to students with IEPs?

Suzanne Galusi: Approximately 15 students per grade level per school. We are still finalizing the staffing but aim to keep the groups small. Yes, open to students with IEPs.

Jenny Graham: Do you need a vote of approval to release ESSER funds?

Dave Murphy: It was in the budget last year so you already approved it.

Mea Mustone: Can kids take a late bus to whatever stop?

Suzanne Galusi: Yes

Sharon Hays: If there are more than 16 kids, is there an opportunity to expand per grade level.

Suzanne Galusi: If I am able to staff it, I will.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: Can we get an update once you have the data? I would love to know how many groupings we have in each school?

Suzanne Galusi: Yes

Paul Ruseau: We know that all of the elementary schools are not the same. Some schools have more students at lower levels than others.

Suzanne Galusi: It is going to be the same datasets so it will be fair. Faiza Khan will be assisting.

Melanie McLaughlin: When you get the data back, can we get some data on how many EL students and students with IEPs.

Suzanne Galusi: I want to make sure I am not exposing confidential information.

Jessica Healy: If a child is on an IEP, will there be special education students offering the instruction?

Suzanne Galusi: There are different staff participating within each building. It is open to all students. It will vary according to the staffing. I can reach out to speak to you specifically about your son.

Christina McGorty: I feel this would be an opportunity to play games and do more conceptual work. If a school is Title 1, then there is more need and in need of more support. The baseline will be the same but it probably will be that the title one schools will need more support.

Suzanne Galusi: I agree with hands-on interactive learning. Illustrative Math does lend itself that sort of instruction.

Nicole DModica, 51 Burnside St: Question regarding the math program. Would it matter if they only had an IEP for Reading and not math to qualify?

Suzanne Galusi: It will be based on NWEA Map testing data, absenteeism rate and class work.

Nicole DiModica: Will they be with peers of similar level?

Suzanne Galusi: With grade level peers of similar levels.

5. Grant updates: Assistant Superintendent of Secondary Education Dr. Peter J. Cushing

We obtained a Grant for financial literacy: curriculum materials and credit for life program for the junior class - grant confirmed

Applied for \$55K grant for Math academy for grades 6-12 over April Vacation. I am concerned about staffing for the program but it will be a rigorous four day program. We will provide breakfast and lunch. I would like to thank Michelle Bissell and Faiza Khan for their help with this grant.

Mea Mustone: Do students self identify for the program or will teachers choose them?

Peter Cushing: Teachers will look at multiple sources of data. We will keep the groups small (12 to 15 students).

Mea Mustone: Is there any incentive for students to participate? This might be a hard sell for students over vacation week.

Melanie McLaughlin: Can we get an update of how many people enroll?

Peter Cushing: Yes.

Jenny Graham: When will the Middle school students get their math results?

Peter Cushing: Should be in the next week.

6. Consideration of SY 22 - 23 Before & After School Care Fee Schedules - Assistant Superintendent of Finance & Operations David Murphy and Director of Student Family Engagement Megan Fidler-Carey will report on proposed fees for SY22-23.

Link to slides

Megan Fidler-Carey: We need to talk about number of seats vs. number of students because not all students attend 5 days. Staffing is an ongoing challenge. High school students are helpful but we can't leave them alone with students.

David Murphy: We need to see an increase in the fee structure while maintaining accessibility and equity. There are a number of unknown variables so there are fluctuations. We have strategic goals to increase access but we need to increase our staffing structure. Vouchers have the intended purpose of providing

access to disadvantaged students. Unfortunately, there are inferences that we are actually creating a barrier to access. If we were to institute a hardship application, the voucher program would reduce our rate of reimbursement. Vouchers are not particularly advantageous and are very administratively burdensome. The SC can consider how long we want to accept a voucher.

A proposed change would be to increase the rate of tuition, and retain use of the voucher program for one more year. Families attaining vouchers for this year would be eligible for the hardship discount going forward for the remainder of the family's time at MPS.

Megan Fidler-Carey: There are currently only 14 students with vouchers. Doing away with vouchers and creating our own hardship scale would be better for access. Many other districts are doing away with vouchers. We thought about raising tuition for next year but for students with free and reduced lunch, we would not increase rates. It was also suggested by a community member that we do away with the four day option because we don't have a one day option.

Dave Murphy: We would like to elevate one role that would help Megan Fidler-Carey manage the program. Also care surround care paraprofessionals with split shifts to provide coverage in the before and after school in addition to working the school day.

Member Paul Ruseau: Do you need motions on any of these things?

Dave Murphy: Yes. We would like a vote regarding the rates of pay. The one outstanding issue is to use the voucher program for one more year but discontinue going forward.

Paul Ruseau: We potentially could have a much higher number of economically disadvantaged students in the future. I would motion to do away with the voucher program this school year.

Dave Murphy: The 14 students on the vouchers have opted into the program. There are many more families who are economically disadvantaged and still participating in the program. Our recommendation is to grandfather in the students who have vouchers now.

Melanie McLaughlin: I am excited about Megan Fidler-Carey being in this role. I am really interested in the para professional piece and accessibility for EL and IEP students. How many families are aware of the voucher program? Do we have a responsibility to the community to inform families about the program? Can we have some outreach and education on the availability of vouchers? The hardship application seems ambiguous. How do we create a bridge before we build the system? I would like to know what families want. Should the family engagement subcommittee look at this?

Dave Murphy: That makes sense to communicate it for this next year. Two concerns: if we just see the same rate of communication, all we have done is create a bigger burden. The other: if the floodgates open and we get a big response from families with vouchers, we will most likely have to continue the voucher program.

Melanie McLaughlin: What if someone comes in with a voucher after we have stopped accepting them?

Megan Fidler-Carey: We currently have on our website that we accept the vouchers, however if someone came in with a voucher they would most likely meet the guidelines to our new discounted program and we would honor the voucher. That is what many districts like Holliston. Most districts in the group I meet with have dropped the voucher program.

Melanie McLaughlin: Thank you for this information. It seems like the EEC has some work to do.

Megan Fidler-Carey: I have met with my liaison with the EEC and have voiced all these concerns and it was not the first time they have heard it.

Dave Murphy: In regards to the hardship waiver, that would have to be fleshed out. We would look at how we currently handle the MEEP program as a starting point. There are situations where we have provided temporary hardship waivers for families experiencing financial instability. I don't think there is a strong argument for continuing the EEC voucher program in perpetuity. This model we have presented tonight does include freezing the current rate for families identified as economically disadvantaged.

Kathy Kreatz: do we currently have students enrolled in the four day option right now?

Megan Fidler-Carey: Not many. Most families would need all five rather than just four.

Kathy Kreatz: Would we reach out in advance to let them know of this change?

Megan Fidler-Carey: Yes.

Jenny Graham: I would like to motion getting rid of the voucher system now to create a more equitable system moving forward.

Dave Murphy: If the question is will more families who are economically disadvantaged get a discounted rate? Yes but there are a lot of variables that will affect our decisions on a year to year basis.

Jenny Graham: Regarding the surround care professionals, will they be part of the paraprofessional union?

Dave Murphy: It would be a subset of the the paraprofessionals and not all after school programming staff will be surround care professionals.

Jenny Graham: Your report doesn't point to all the people on the waitlist. This year we were not able to expand seats due to worker shortage. Is there a chance of expanding seats for next year? How do we crack that nut? Will this actually create space?

Dave Murphy: It is a shared goal. We want to expand seats. We will try again this year.

Jenny Graham: How do we deal with a lottery?

Megan Fidler-Carey: The open seats are generally for the Kindergarten students. I won't know yet about who is committing for next year and what siblings they have.

Jenny Graham: The other thing is this notion that once you are on the list you are in forever?

Megan Fidler-Carey: We could try by getting rid of the waitlist and re-entering people back in the lottery. We could explore it.

Jenny Graham: I am sensitive to those who move to the district after Kindergarten have no chance. I know the answer is to have enough seats.

Megan Fidler-Carey: The demand in Medford is huge because we don't have many outside options.

Dave Murphy: The increase in tuition and increasing the seats are two ways of keeping a smaller waiting list.

Jenny Graham: If staffing is the issue and the para program takes hold, could we expand?

Dave Murphy: Our obstacle is staffing not space.

Sharon Hays: Can we talk about a sliding scale? Can we talk about making sure seats are available to low income families?

Dave Murphy: This proposal is a step towards the sliding scale. My concern about maintaining a health revenue stream, I can't commit to providing a number of free seats. We are prepared to absorb the costs of the voucher.

Sharon Hays: Can we get more information on this?

Dave Murphy: Yes we can get the demographics of the current participants. There is not a magical number of how many free seats with so many unknowns. I have hesitation to make inferences from community members who spoke up last year about paying more for the After School program.

Megan Fidler-Carey: We now have the engagement specialists who can help communicate to families.

Melanie McLaughlin: Your recommendation to defer getting rid of the voucher program. I appreciate the thoughtfulness going into making these changes.

Paul Ruseau: I made a motion to take the recommendation on number two to make it 2022-2023 (getting rid of the voucher program this year). Discontinue eec vouchers at the end of 2021-2022 school year.

Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: YES; Melanie McLaughlin: NO: 6 affirmative/1 negative: motion to discontinue voucher this year.

Jenny Graham: Motion to approve the remainder of the items on the list. Bullets 1, 3, 4, 5 and 6 in After School Slide

Kathy Kreatz: Second.

Roll: Jenny Graham, Sharon Hays, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn

7/0 yes: motion approved

Dave Murphy: We will report back before the end of the school year on the hardship program.

New Business

2022-15 Offered by Paul Ruseau

The Superintendent or her designee(s) will provide a detailed description of bathroom closures/openings at Medford High School. The number of bathrooms at Medford High School will be presented, as well as the number of bathrooms open throughout the day. The timing of bathroom closures/openings and who is responsible for this task will also be included in the details. The rationale for closing bathrooms will also be discussed.

Meeting Date Requested: 2/28/2022

Submitted Date: 2/2/2022

Dave Murphy: the committee received a [memo regarding the scheduling of bathroom openings/closures](#). As our lunchrooms approach more normal scheduling, I expect that there will be more bathrooms open throughout the day.

Paul Ruseau: I appreciate the memo and it is quite detailed. Going pee is only one need of going to the bathroom. We focus on Social/emotional and it could be humiliating for students to not be able to access a bathroom when needed. I just want to know that there are kids who can't get to the bathroom.

Dave Murphy: They are open right now and I know there will be more in the near future. Could there be a time when a student might need to walk further than they should.....yes. We need a better layout for a building.

Paul Ruseau: Is the issue keeping the bathrooms clean?

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Staffing issues, vaping issues, security issues also make this a balancing act.

Jenny Graham: I spoke with some students and I want to make sure that the buildings in the B building are actually open (these are considered the nice bathrooms). The thing that makes me the most irritating is that the principal spoke about making the schedule known to students but no students actually are aware of a schedule. The conversation is whether the bathrooms are suitable enough. Students definitely said lunch time is particularly bad.

Condolences

The Medford School Committee extends its sincere condolences to the family of Lorraine Miller, aunt to Medford High School Resource Officer Richard Ziobro.

The Medford School Committee extends its sincere condolences to the family of Louis F. Vendice, Jr., father to former DARE Officer Robin Doherty.

The Medford School Committee extends its sincere condolences to the family of Lisa (Bouchard) Layton, who was an active volunteer at the former Dame and Missituk (Columbus) Elementary Schools.

The Medford School Committee extends its sincere condolences to the family of Michael F. Antonelli, a former social studies teacher at Medford High School.

The Medford School Committee extends its sincere condolences to the family of Mr. Richard A. MacDonald, father-in-law of Assistant Superintendent of Secondary Education Dr. Peter J. Cushing.

Next Meeting

- **Monday, March 7, 2022, 6:30PM: Regular School Committee Meeting** - Alden Memorial Chambers, Medford City Hall in addition to zoom:
<https://mps02155-org.zoom.us/j/94990956841>

Motion to adjourn the meeting: Jenny Graham/Kathy Kreatz

All in favor.

Meeting adjourned at 9:15PM